

SELF-LOADING RIFLES

The old bolt-action rifles developed during the final years of the 19th century were still in service at the outbreak of World War II, and despite their age remained highly effective. But the war proved to be a transitional stage for the rifle. The first major breakthrough took place with the introduction of the self-loading rifle, which allowed repeated shots to be fired by simply pulling the trigger. The key development, however, came with the German Sturmgewehr 44, the first assault rifle and forerunner of the AK47, its revolutionary medium-powered $7.92 \times 33\text{mm}$ cartridge allowing soldiers to deliver effective automatic fire for the first time.

► MOSIN-NAGANT M1891/30PU

Date 1930

Origin Soviet Union

Weight 4kg (8½lb)

Barrel 73cm (29in)

Calibre 7.62mm

The M1891/30 was the standard rifle of the Red Army during World War II. Selected models of the rifle were fitted with a 3.5-power PU telescopic sight, to be used by snipers.



▲ M1 GARAND RIFLE

Date 1932

Origin US

Weight 4.31kg (9½lb)

Barrel 61cm (24in)

Calibre .30-06

Designed by John Garand, the M1 rifle was the first general issue, self-loading rifle to be accepted for military service. By the end of World War II, over five million of them had been manufactured.



▲ LEE ENFIELD RIFLE NO. 4

Date 1939

Origin UK

Weight 4.1kg (9lb)

Barrel 64cm (25in)

Calibre .303in

A successor to the SMLE rifle of World War I fame, the Lee Enfield rifle No. 4 had a heavier barrel and a relocated rear sight, and was designed for mass production.



▲ MAUSER KAR98K

Date 1935

Origin Germany

Weight 3.9kg (8½lb)

Barrel 60cm (23½in)

Calibre 7.92mm × 57

The "Karabiner" 98K was a modified version of the Gewehr 98, and became the standard German rifle of World War II. More than 14 million were manufactured between 1935 and 1945. During that time, the design was further simplified to speed up production.

